Reintroducing beavers to the UK



Beavers were wiped out in the UK 400 years ago, but the beneficial role of this keystone mammal is now better understood. Beavers are ecological engineers, building dams and canals, and their presence increases biodiversity.

In 2009, 11 beavers were reintroduced to Knapdale Forest, Scotland, and in 2011, the Devon Wildlife Trust introduced a pair to a fenced area. Both projects were monitored for their impact on the environment. In Knapdale Forest, the beavers' dams changed the water level of a loch, and Devon's beavers built several dams on the River Tamar, creating 13 new freshwater pools and making surrounding areas wetter.

In Devon, the damp areas created by beavers increased the number of bryophyte species (mosses and liverworts), and the range of aquatic invertebrates rose from 14 to 41 species. Greater numbers of flying insects have also improved bat diversity, with two nationally rare bat species drawn into the area. Beavers were subsequently officially recognized as a native species in England, and further reintroduction programs have taken place.

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